ontology

NOUN

Etymology

Summary

A borrowing from Latin.

Etymon: Latin *ontologia*.

< **post-classical Latin** *ontologia* (1613 in Greek characters in R. Goclenius *Lexicon Philosophicum* 16) < *onto-* **onto-** *comb. form* + *-logia* **-logy** *comb. form*. Compare **French** *ontologie* (1692), **German** *Ontologie* (1764 or earlier). Compare later **ontologic** *adj.*, **ontological** *adj.*

Notes

J. Clauberg (*Metaphysica*, 1646) suggests **post-classical Latin** *ontologia* as an alternative to *metaphysica*, citing Aristotle's definition of the science at *Metaphysics* 1005[a]3, where he describes it as the science or study of being, that which exists, **ancient Greek** *ὄν* (see **onto-** *comb. form*).

Meaning & use

1.a. *Philosophy*. The science or study of being; that branch of metaphysics concerned with the nature or essence of being or existence. **1663–**

1663 Metaphysics..is called also the first Philosophy, from its nearest approximation to Philosophy, its most proper Denomination is *Ontology*, or a Discourse of a Being.
G. Harvey, *Archelogia Philosophica Nova* vol. I. ii. i. 18

1721 *Ontology*, an Account of being in the Abstract.
N. Bailey, *Universal Etymological English Dictionary*

1776 Subtleties and sophisms..composed the whole of this cobweb science of Ontology, which was likewise sometimes called Metaphysics.
A. Smith, *Inquiry Wealth of Nations* vol. II. v. i. 354

***a*1832** The field of ontology, or as it may otherwise be termed, the field of supremely abstract entities, is a yet untrodden labyrinth.
J. Bentham, *Fragm. Ontol.* in *Works* (1843) vol. VIII. 195

1865 We cordially approve and admire,..not least, the signal demolition of Ontology, in the form of the *noumenon*, or unknowable substratum of matter and mind.
Reader 8 July 30

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1884 Ontology ..as a doctrine of the being and relations of all reality, had precedence given to it over Cosmology and Psychology, the two branches of enquiry which follow the reality into its opposite distinctive forms.
B. Bosanquet et al., translation of H. Lotze, *Metaphysic* 22

1903 The effect of what Kant called the Copernican revolution in philosophy is that ontology, the theory of Reality, comes to be conditioned by epistemology, the theory of our knowledge.
F. C. S. Schiller, *Humanism* i. 9

1960 Comte had to..repudiate not only metaphysics but also ontology. Thus would he deprive science of any and every claim to deal with objective reality.
C. C. Gillispie, *Edge of Objectivity* xi. 496

1988 To admit that in some sense events exist is not to admit that events as arbitrary objects have any significance for the ontology of causality.
Mind vol. 97 537

philosophy

1.b. As a count noun: a theory or conception relating to the nature of being. Also in extended use. **1855–**

1855 [Rationalism] might do but little harm in..disporting itself with its own fanciful creations..respecting necessity and spontaneity.., quiddities and ontologies.
A. Potter, *Lect. Evidence Christianity* 197

1888 We are ready to admit all the hard things the Comte has said of the old Ontologies.
Mind vol. 13 64

1909 Even in the most nihilistic of ontologies the eternal is meant to be functional, not be merely the blank and irrelevant negation of temporality.
Philosophical Review vol. 18 490

1950 Today we need new ontologies constructed in the light of what science now tells us about man.
Science Monthly May 346/2

1995 In trying together prayer and ethics, Barth explores a moral ontology and a moral anthropology in which dependence is not diminishment and resolute action is not self-assertion.
Church Times 3 November 13/4

2. *Logic.* Chiefly with reference to the work of Stanislaw Leśniewski (1886–1939): a system similar in scope to modern predicate logic, which attempts to interpret quantifiers without assuming that anything exists beyond written expressions. **1938–**

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S. Leśniewski first developed this system of ontology in conjunction with the logical systems of mereology and protothetic. Cf. **mereology** *n.*, **protothetic** *n.*

1938 There is also included a sketch of Leśniewski's *ontology* or theory of classes.
Journal of Symbolic Logic vol. 3 169

1955 The basis of Leśniewski's logic is the ‘prototheticʼ..and on this he builds two further disciplines called ‘ontologyʼ and ‘mereologyʼ.
A. N. Prior, *Formal Logic* iii. iii. 293

1983 The proposed Lesniewskian-type ontology for natural language is related via a translation to the Montague grammar of a traditional type.
Journal of Symbolic Logic vol. 48 522

logic

Pronunciation

BRITISH ENGLISH

/ɒnˈtɒlədʒi/

on-TOL-uh-jee

U.S. ENGLISH

/ɑnˈtɑlədʒi/

ahn-TAH-luh-jee

Pronunciation keys

Frequency

ontology typically occurs about four times per million words in modern written English.

ontology is in frequency band 5, which contains words occurring between 1 and 10 times per million words in modern written English. More about OED's frequency bands

Frequency data is computed programmatically, and should be regarded as an estimate.

Frequency of *ontology, n.*, 1750–2010

* Occurrences per million words in written English

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Historical frequency series are derived from Google Books Ngrams (version 2), a data set based on the Google Books corpus of several million books printed in English between 1500 and 2010.

The overall frequency for a given word is calculated by summing frequencies for the main form of the word, any plural or inflected forms, and any major spelling variations.

For sets of homographs (distinct entries that share the same word-form, e.g. *mole*, n.[1], *mole*, n.[2], *mole*, n.[3], etc.), we have estimated the frequency of each homograph entry as a fraction of the total Ngrams frequency for the word-form. This may result in inaccuracies.

Smoothing has been applied to series for lower-frequency words, using a moving-average algorithm. This reduces short-term fluctuations, which may be produced by variability in the content of the Google Books corpus.

Frequency of *ontology, n.*, 2017–2023

* Occurrences per million words in written English

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Modern frequency series are derived from a corpus of 20 billion words, covering the period from 2017 to the present. The corpus is mainly compiled from online news sources, and covers all major varieties of World English.

Smoothing has been applied to series for lower-frequency words, using a moving-average algorithm. This reduces short-term fluctuations, which may be produced by variability in the content of the corpus.

Compounds & derived words

Sort by Date (oldest first)

ontologist, n. **1727–**
A student of or expert in ontology; a metaphysician.

ontologize, v. **1849–**
intransitive. To apply or deal with ontology.

ontologism, n. **1850–**
A mystical system based on the belief that God is directly and immediately apprehended by the mind as the first object of human intelligence.

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